

Latin Jazz & Tango Improvisation Syllabus

For Alto & Tenor Saxophone

A 16-Week Practice Program
Scales in All 12 Keys | ii-V-i Progressions | Tango Cadences

Companion to the FQBK Scale & Chord Reference

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Phase 1: Foundation

Weeks 1-4 | Goal: Core scale fluency in common Latin jazz keys | 30-45 min/day

Always practice with a **clave pattern** (son clave 3-2 or 2-3). Tap the clave with your foot.

Scale 1: DORIAN (Minor) - The Latin Jazz Workhorse

Use over: minor 7th vamps, montuno grooves, ii chords | **Formula:** W H W W W H W

Key	Notes	Concert (Alto)	Concert (Tenor)	Context
C-7	C D Eb F G A Bb	Eb min	Bb min	
Db-7	Db Eb Fb Gb Ab Bb Cb	E min	B min	
D-7	D E F G A B C	F min	C min	Very common
Eb-7	Eb F Gb Ab Bb C Db	Gb min	Db min	
E-7	E F# G A B C# D	G min	D min	Very common
F-7	F G Ab Bb C D Eb	Ab min	Eb min	Common
F#-7	F# G# A B C# D# E	A min	E min	
G-7	G A Bb C D E F	Bb min	F min	Very common
Ab-7	Ab Bb Cb Db Eb F Gb	B min	Gb min	
A-7	A B C D E F# G	C min	G min	Very common
Bb-7	Bb C Db Eb F G Ab	Db min	Ab min	Common
B-7	B C# D E F# G# A	D min	A min	Common

Priority Practice Order

1. D Dorian (concert F/C minor)
2. G Dorian (concert Bb/F minor)
3. A Dorian (concert C/G minor)
4. E Dorian (concert G/D minor)
5. C Dorian (concert Eb/Bb minor)
6. F Dorian (concert Ab/Eb minor)
7. Bb Dorian (concert Db/Ab minor)
8. Then fill in remaining keys

Scale 2: MIXOLYDIAN - Over Dominant Chords

Use over: dominant 7th chords, V7 chords | **Formula:** W W H W W H W

Key	Notes	Concert (Alto)	Concert (Tenor)
C7	C D E F G A Bb	Eb7	Bb7
Db7	Db Eb F Gb Ab Bb Cb	E7	B7
D7	D E F# G A B C	F7	C7
Eb7	Eb F G Ab Bb C Db	Gb7	Db7
E7	E F# G# A B C# D	G7	D7
F7	F G A Bb C D Eb	Ab7	Eb7
F#7	F# G# A# B C# D# E	A7	E7

Key	Notes	Concert (Alto)	Concert (Tenor)
G7	G A B C D E F	Bb7	F7
Ab7	Ab Bb C Db Eb F Gb	B7	Gb7
A7	A B C# D E F# G	C7	G7
Bb7	Bb C D Eb F G Ab	Db7	Ab7
B7	B C# D# E F# G# A	D7	A7

Scale 3: MINOR PENTATONIC - Clean Rhythmic Lines

Use over: minor vamps, simple blowing sections | **Formula:** m3 W W m3 W

Key	Notes (5 notes)
C	C Eb F G Bb
Db	Db Fb Gb Ab Cb
D	D F G A C
Eb	Eb Gb Ab Bb Db
E	E G A B D
F	F Ab Bb C Eb
F#	F# A B C# E
G	G Bb C D F
Ab	Ab Cb Db Eb Gb
A	A C D E G
Bb	Bb Db Eb F Ab
B	B D E F# A

Scale 4: BLUES SCALE - Grit and Soul

Use over: everything! | **Formula:** m3 W H H m3 W

Key	Notes (6 notes)
C	C Eb F F# G Bb
Db	Db Fb Gb G Ab Cb
D	D F G G# A C
Eb	Eb Gb Ab A Bb Db
E	E G A A# B D
F	F Ab Bb B C Eb
F#	F# A B B# C# E
G	G Bb C C# D F
Ab	Ab Cb Db D Eb Gb
A	A C D D# E G
Bb	Bb Db Eb E F Ab
B	B D E E# F# A

Week-by-Week Schedule

Week 1: D Dorian + G Mixolydian + D Minor Pentatonic (ii-V in C minor)

Week 2: G Dorian + C Mixolydian + G Minor Pentatonic (ii-V in F minor)

Week 3: A Dorian + D Mixolydian + A Minor Pentatonic (ii-V in G minor)

Week 4: Review all 3 key centers + add E, C, F Dorian. Record yourself.

Clave Rhythm Reference

Son Clave 3-2: X . . X . . X . | . . X . . X . .

Son Clave 2-3: . . X . . X . . | X . . X . . X .

Rumba Clave 3-2: X . . X . . . X | . . X . . X . .

Phase 2: Harmonic Depth

Weeks 5-8 | Goal: Navigate ii-V-i progressions | 30-45 min/day

Spanish / Jewish (Phrygian Dominant) - THE Latin Dominant Sound

Use over: V7b9 chords resolving to minor | **Formula:** H m3 H W H W W

5th mode of Harmonic Minor. The b9 interval is what makes salsa, mambo, and tango distinctive.

Key	Notes	Resolves to
C7b9	C Db E F G Ab Bb	F minor
Db7b9	Db Ebb F Gb Ab Bbb Cb	Gb minor
D7b9	D Eb F# G A Bb C	G minor
Eb7b9	Eb Fb G Ab Bb Cb Db	Ab minor
E7b9	E F G# A B C D	A minor
F7b9	F Gb A Bb C Db Eb	Bb minor
F#7b9	F# G A# B C# D E	B minor
G7b9	G Ab B C D Eb F	C minor
Ab7b9	Ab Bbb C Db Eb Fb Gb	Db minor
A7b9	A Bb C# D E F G	D minor
Bb7b9	Bb Cb D Eb F Gb Ab	Eb minor
B7b9	B C D# E F# G A	E minor

Harmonic Minor - Dramatic Resolutions & Tango

Use over: minor tonic, V7-i cadences | **Formula:** W H W W H m3 H

Key	Notes	Augmented 2nd
C	C D Eb F G Ab B	Ab-B
Db	Db Eb Fb Gb Ab Bbb C	
D	D E F G A Bb C#	Bb-C#
Eb	Eb F Gb Ab Bb Cb D	
E	E F# G A B C D#	C-D#
F	F G Ab Bb C Db E	Db-E
F#	F# G# A B C# D E#	
G	G A Bb C D Eb F#	Eb-F#
Ab	Ab Bb Cb Db Eb Fb G	
A	A B C D E F G#	F-G#
Bb	Bb C Db Eb F Gb A	Gb-A
B	B C# D E F# G A#	G-A#

Melodic Minor - Modern Tango Tonic

Use over: minor-major7 chords | **Formula:** W H W W W W H

Key	Notes (ascending)
C	C D Eb F G A B
Db	Db Eb Fb Gb Ab Bb C
D	D E F G A B C#
Eb	Eb F Gb Ab Bb C D
E	E F# G A B C# D#
F	F G Ab Bb C D E
F#	F# G# A B C# D# E#
G	G A Bb C D E F#
Ab	Ab Bb Cb Db Eb F G
A	A B C D E F# G#
Bb	Bb C Db Eb F G A
B	B C# D E F# G# A#

Bebop Dominant - Smooth Eighth-Note Lines

Use over: dominant 7th chords | **Formula:** W W H W W H H H (8 notes)

Key	Notes (8 notes)
C7	C D E F G A Bb B
Db7	Db Eb F Gb Ab Bb Cb C
D7	D E F# G A B C C#
Eb7	Eb F G Ab Bb C Db D
E7	E F# G# A B C# D D#
F7	F G A Bb C D Eb E
F#7	F# G# A# B C# D# E E#
G7	G A B C D E F F#
Ab7	Ab Bb C Db Eb F Gb G
A7	A B C# D E F# G G#
Bb7	Bb C D Eb F G Ab A
B7	B C# D# E F# G# A A#

Lydian Dominant - Static Dominant Chords

Use over: dominant chords that don't resolve down a 5th | **Formula:** W W W H W H W

Key	Notes
C7#4	C D E F# G A Bb
Db7#4	Db Eb F G Ab Bb Cb
D7#4	D E F# G# A B C
Eb7#4	Eb F G A Bb C Db
E7#4	E F# G# A# B C# D

Key	Notes
F7#4	F G A B C D Eb
F#7#4	F# G# A# B# C# D# E
G7#4	G A B C# D E F
Ab7#4	Ab Bb C D Eb F Gb
A7#4	A B C# D# E F# G
Bb7#4	Bb C D E F G Ab
B7#4	B C# D# E# F# G# A

MASTER CHART: ii-V-i in All 12 Minor Keys

The core latin jazz progression. Practice each row as a unit.

Key	ii (Dorian)	V (Spanish/Jewish)	i (Harmonic Minor)
C min	D: D E F G A B C	G7b9: G Ab B C D Eb F	C: C D Eb F G Ab B
Db min	Eb: Eb F Gb Ab Bb C Db	Ab7b9: Ab Bbb C Db Eb Fb Gb	Db: Db Eb Fb Gb Ab Bbb C
D min	E: E F# G A B C# D	A7b9: A Bb C# D E F G	D: D E F G A Bb C#
Eb min	F: F G Ab Bb C D Eb	Bb7b9: Bb Cb D Eb F Gb Ab	Eb: Eb F Gb Ab Bb Cb D
E min	F#: F# G# A B C# D# E	B7b9: B C D# E F# G A	E: E F# G A B C D#
F min	G: G A Bb C D E F	C7b9: C Db E F G Ab Bb	F: F G Ab Bb C Db E
F# min	G#: G# A# B C# D# E# F#	C#7b9: C# D E# F# G# A B	F#: F# G# A B C# D E#
G min	A: A B C D E F# G	D7b9: D Eb F# G A Bb C	G: G A Bb C D Eb F#
Ab min	Bb: Bb C Db Eb F G Ab	Eb7b9: Eb Fb G Ab Bb Cb Db	Ab: Ab Bb Cb Db Eb Fb G
A min	B: B C# D E F# G# A	E7b9: E F G# A B C D	A: A B C D E F G#
Bb min	C: C D Eb F G A Bb	F7b9: F Gb A Bb C Db Eb	Bb: Bb C Db Eb F Gb A
B min	C#: C# D# E F# G# A# B	F#7b9: F# G A# B C# D E	B: B C# D E F# G A#

Practice Method: 4 beats Dorian, 4 beats Spanish/Jewish, 8 beats Harmonic Minor. Repeat.

Week-by-Week Schedule

Week 5: Spanish/Jewish in 4 keys (G, D, A, C). Compare to Mixolydian.

Week 6: Add Harmonic Minor. Connect full ii-V-i in C, G, D, F minor.

Week 7: Add Melodic Minor + Bebop Dominant for flowing lines.

Week 8: All 12 keys. Add Lydian Dominant over static vamps. Record yourself.

Phase 3: Color & Tension

Weeks 9-12 | Goal: Tension, release, and outside playing | 30-45 min/day

Altered Scale (Diminished Whole Tone) - Maximum Tension

Use over: V7#9, V7b9, V7#5 | Formula: H W H W W W W | Contains: root, b9, #9, 3, #11, b13, b7

Key	Notes
C7alt	C Db D# E F# G# Bb
Db7alt	Db Ebb E F G A Cb
D7alt	D Eb E# F# G# A# C
Eb7alt	Eb Fb F# G A B Db
E7alt	E F F## G# A# B# D
F7alt	F Gb G# A B C# Eb
F#7alt	F# G A Bb C D E
G7alt	G Ab A# B C# D# F
Ab7alt	Ab Bbb B C D E Gb
A7alt	A Bb B# C# D# E# G
Bb7alt	Bb Cb C# D E F# Ab
B7alt	B C C## D# E# F## A

Whole Tone - Dreamy Floating Sound

Use over: V7#5 | Formula: W W W W W W | Only 2 unique whole tone scales exist

Key	Notes	WT Scale
C7#5	C D E F# G# Bb	1
Db7#5	Db Eb F G A Cb	2
D7#5	D E F# G# A# C	1
Eb7#5	Eb F G A B Db	2
E7#5	E F# G# A# B# D	1
F7#5	F G A B C# Eb	2
Gb7#5	Gb Ab Bb C D Fb	1
G7#5	G A B C# D# F	2
Ab7#5	Ab Bb C D E Gb	1
A7#5	A B C# D# E# G	2
Bb7#5	Bb C D E F# Ab	1
B7#5	B C# D# E# F## A	2

Diminished (begin with H) - Angular Dominant Sound

Use over: V7b9 | Formula: H W H W H W H W (8 notes, symmetric)

Key	Notes (8 notes)
C7b9	C Db D# E F# G A Bb
Db7b9	Db Ebb E F G Ab Bb Cb
D7b9	D Eb E# F# G# A B C
Eb7b9	Eb Fb F# G A Bb C Db
E7b9	E F F## G# A# B C# D
F7b9	F Gb G# A B C D Eb
G7b9	G Ab A# B C# D E F
Ab7b9	Ab Bbb B C D Eb F Gb
A7b9	A Bb B# C# D# E F# G
Bb7b9	Bb Cb C# D E F G Ab
B7b9	B C C## D# E# F# G# A

Phrygian - Dark Modal Vamps

Use over: modal minor sections, descarga grooves | **Formula:** H W W W H W W

Key	Notes
C	C Db Eb F G Ab Bb
C#	C# D E F# G# A B
D	D Eb F G A Bb C
Eb	Eb Fb Gb Ab Bb Cb Db
E	E F G A B C D
F	F Gb Ab Bb C Db Eb
F#	F# G A B C# D E
G	G Ab Bb C D Eb F
G#	G# A B C# D# E F#
A	A Bb C D E F G
Bb	Bb Cb Db Eb F Gb Ab
B	B C D E F# G A

Tension-Resolution Exercise (All 12 Keys)

Practice: 2 bars tension (Altered) then 2 bars resolution (Dorian)

Resolve to	V7 Altered Scale	i Dorian Scale
C min	G: G Ab A# B C# D# F	C: C D Eb F G A Bb
D min	A: A Bb B# C# D# E# G	D: D E F G A B C
E min	B: B C C## D# E# F## A	E: E F# G A B C# D
F min	C: C Db D# E F# G# Bb	F: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
G min	D: D Eb E# F# G# A# C	G: G A Bb C D E F
A min	E: E F F## G# A# B# D	A: A B C D E F# G

Resolve to	V7 Altered Scale	i Dorian Scale
Bb min	F: F Gb G# A B C# Eb	Bb: Bb C Db Eb F G Ab
B min	F#: F# G A Bb C D E	B: B C# D E F# G# A

Week-by-Week Schedule

Week 9: Altered Scale in 4 keys + tension-resolution exercise.

Week 10: Whole Tone + Diminished. Compare all dominant tensions.

Week 11: Phrygian over dark vamps + Diminished (W-H) for outside color.

Week 12: Integration. Improvise over full tunes with ALL tension scales.

Phase 4: Advanced & Tango

Weeks 13-16 | Goal: Real-world application + tango vocabulary | 45-60 min/day

Lydian Augmented

Use over: Major #5 chords, III chords in minor | **Formula:** W W W W H W H

Key	Notes
C	C D E F# G# A B
D	D E F# G# A# B C#
E	E F# G# A# B# C# D#
F	F G A B C# D E
G	G A B C# D# E F#
A	A B C# D# E# F# G#
Bb	Bb C D E F# G A
B	B C# D# E# F## G# A#

Locrian #2 - Smooth Half-Diminished

Use over: half-diminished chords | **Formula:** W H W H W W W

Key	Notes
C	C D Eb F Gb Ab Bb
D	D E F G Ab Bb C
E	E F# G A Bb C D
F	F G Ab Bb Cb Db Eb
G	G A Bb C Db Eb F
A	A B C D Eb F G
Bb	Bb C Db Eb Fb Gb Ab
B	B C# D E F G A

Hindu (Mixolydian b6) - Melancholic Dominant

Use over: dominant b6 chords | **Formula:** W W H W H W W

Key	Notes
C7b6	C D E F G Ab Bb
D7b6	D E F# G A Bb C
E7b6	E F# G# A B C D
F7b6	F G A Bb C Db Eb
G7b6	G A B C D Eb F
A7b6	A B C# D E F G
Bb7b6	Bb C D Eb F Gb Ab
B7b6	B C# D# E F# G A

TANGO-SPECIFIC PRACTICE

The Tango Scale Palette

Scale	Tango Function	Emotional Quality
Harmonic Minor	Primary tonic scale	Dramatic, passionate
Spanish/Jewish	Over V7b9	Yearning, bittersweet
Melodic Minor	Modern tango tonic	Sophisticated, smooth
Diminished (H-W)	Passing diminished chords	Mysterious, tense
Phrygian	Dark modal sections	Brooding, intense
Natural Minor	Folk tango	Simple, melancholic

Tango Phrygian Cadence: bII - V7b9 - i (All Keys)

The signature tango resolution pattern.

Key	bII (Lydian)	V7b9 (Spanish)	i (Harm. Minor)
C min	Db: Db Eb F G Ab Bb C	G7b9: G Ab B C D Eb F	C: C D Eb F G Ab B
D min	Eb: Eb F G A Bb C D	A7b9: A Bb C# D E F G	D: D E F G A Bb C#
E min	F: F G A B C D E	B7b9: B C D# E F# G A	E: E F# G A B C D#
F min	Gb: Gb Ab Bb C Db Eb F	C7b9: C Db E F G Ab Bb	F: F G Ab Bb C Db E
G min	Ab: Ab Bb C D Eb F G	D7b9: D Eb F# G A Bb C	G: G A Bb C D Eb F#
A min	Bb: Bb C D E F G A	E7b9: E F G# A B C D	A: A B C D E F G#
Bb min	Cb: Cb Db Eb F Gb Ab Bb	F7b9: F Gb A Bb C Db Eb	Bb: Bb C Db Eb F Gb A
B min	C: C D E F# G A B	F#7b9: F# G A# B C# D E	B: B C# D E F# G A#

Tango Melodic Vocabulary

Chromatic Neighbors: Approach each harmonic minor note from a half step below.

Dramatic Leaps: Jump up a 6th or 7th, then walk back down stepwise.

3-3-2 Rhythm: X . . X . . X . over 4/4 - the tango rhythmic DNA.

Marcato vs Sincopa: Heavy quarter notes vs syncopated push. Switch mid-phrase.

Week-by-Week Schedule

Week 13: Tango cadences in C, D, G, A minor. Chromatic neighbor exercise.

Week 14: Lydian Augmented, Locrian #2, Hindu over specific chord types.

Week 15: Pick 3 latin jazz standards. Map every chord to a scale. Improvise.

Week 16: All tango cadences in 12 keys. 3-3-2 rhythm. Transcribe Piazzolla.

Riffs, Licks & Melodic Patterns

Common vocabulary for Latin Jazz & Tango improvisation. Learn in C, then transpose to all keys.

1. LATIN JAZZ RIFFS - Over Minor Vamps (Dorian)

Play these over a Dm7 or Cm7 montuno groove with clave. Written in D Dorian (concert F/C).

Riff	Notes (in D Dorian)	Rhythm Feel	Technique
Pentatonic Call	D F G A C D	Ascending burst on 3-side of clave	Strong attack, let last note ring
Falling Answer	C A G F D	Descending on 2-side of clave	Softer, legato response
The Montuno Riff	D F A - C A F	Up in 3rds, back down	Staccato, match piano montuno rhythm
Root-5th Anchor	D . A . D' . A . D	Quarter notes, marcato	Strong foundation riff
Dorian Signature	D E F A G E D	1-2-b3-5-4-2-1 shape	Emphasize the natural 6th (B)
Blue Note Dip	D F G G# A C D	Add blues b5 passing tone	Bend into the G#, slide to A
Clave Melody	D . . F . . A .	Notes on clave hits only	Let space do the work
Syncopated 3rds	D-F . E-G . F-A . G-Bb	Pairs on upbeats	Push ahead of the beat

2. ii-V-i LICKS - The Core Latin Jazz Vocabulary

Written for ii-V-i in C minor: Dm7 - G7b9 - Cm. Transpose to all 12 keys.

Lick	Dm7 (beats 1-2)	G7b9 (beats 3-4)	Cm (bar 2)	Character
Smooth Dorian-Spanish	D E F G	Ab B D F	Eb D C	Classic, clean
Bebop Connector	A G F E	F Ab B D	Eb C	Descending into tension
Enclosure Lick	E D F E	Ab G B Ab	G Eb D C	Surround target notes
Arpeggio + Scale	D F A C	B D F Ab	G Eb D C	Chord tones then fill
Altered Tension	D F G A	Ab Bb Db E (altered)	Eb D C	Max tension on V
Pentatonic Shift	D F G A C	Db Fb Gb Ab (Db pent)	C Eb G	Pentatonic substitution
Chromatic Approach	A G F E	Eb D Db C B	C	Half steps into resolution
Spanish Signature	D E F G	G Ab B C D Eb F	Eb D C	Full Spanish run on V

How to practice: Play each lick slowly with a metronome. Then loop a Dm7-G7-Cm backing track and cycle through all 8 licks. Once comfortable, transpose to G minor (Am7-D7b9-Gm), then all keys.

3. DOMINANT 7th RIFFS - Spicing Up the V Chord

Different ways to play over G7 resolving to C minor. Each gives a different flavor.

Flavor	Scale Used	Example Riff (over G7)	Sound
Vanilla	G Mixolydian	G A B D C B A G	Safe, consonant

Flavor	Scale Used	Example Riff (over G7)	Sound
Salsa Fire	G Spanish/Jewish	G Ab B C D Eb F G	Classic Afro-Cuban
Bebop Flow	G Bebop Dominant	G A B C D E F F# G	Smooth 8th notes
Dark Mystery	G Dim (H-W)	G Ab A# B C# D E F	Angular, symmetric
Maximum Heat	G Altered	G Ab Bb B Db Eb F	Outside, unresolved
Floating	G Whole Tone	G A B C# D# F	Dreamy, suspended
Blues Grit	G Blues	G Bb C C# D F	Earthy, soulful
Lydian Static	G Lydian Dom	G A B C# D E F	Bright, non-resolving

4. PENTATONIC TRICKS - Simple but Powerful

The minor pentatonic is the secret weapon of latin jazz. These patterns work in any key.

Pattern Name	Shape (in D minor pent: D F G A C)	Application
Ascending 4ths	D-G, F-A, G-C, A-D	Strong, angular, modern
Falling 3rds	A-F, G-D, F-C, D-A	Smooth, flowing descent
Skip Pattern	D G F A G C A D'	Zigzag through the scale
Repeated Cell	D F G - F G A - G A C	3-note groups, shifting up
Call & Response	D F G A (high) ... C A G F (answer)	Leave space between phrases
Octave Displacement	D(low) F(high) G(low) A(high)	Jump octaves for drama
Clave Pentatonic	D . . F . . G . / . . A . . C . .	Place notes only on clave hits
Pent over V7	Play Ab min pent over G7	Ab Cb Db Eb Gb = b9 3 b5 b13 b7 of G7

5. TANGO MELODIC PATTERNS

Signature tango gestures. Written in A minor (concert C/G). Use 3-3-2 rhythmic feel.

Pattern	Notes	Description
The Tango Sigh	B C B A G# A	Upper neighbor, fall back - yearning quality
Dramatic Leap + Descent	A(low) - F(up 6th) E D C B A	Jump up, walk down stepwise
Augmented 2nd Cry	E F G# A G# F E	Mirror around the F-G# aug 2nd interval
Chromatic Approach	G G# A - B C - D D# E	Lead into each chord tone from below
Phrygian Cadence Lick	Bb A G# A - F E D# E	bII sound melting into V then i
Bandoneon Imitation	A E' C A E C A	Descending arpeggiated pattern, staccato
3-3-2 Harmonic Minor	A B C / D E F / G# A	Group harmonic minor in 3-3-2
Double Neighbor	G# Bb A - D# F E	Surround from above and below
Piazzolla Sequence	A C E - B D F - C E G#	Rising 3rds through harmonic minor
Tango Ending	E D# E - F E D C B A	Turn on the 5th, descend to tonic

6. RHYTHMIC PATTERNS TO APPLY TO ANY SCALE

Apply these rhythms to any of the scales above. X = play note, . = rest, > = accent

Pattern	Rhythm (over 2 bars of 4/4)	Style
Son Clave Melody	X . . X . . X . . . X . . X . .	Fundamental latin jazz phrasing
Anticipated Downbeat	. . . X X X X . . .	Push the 'one' - syncopated salsa feel
Tresillo	X . . X . . X . X . . X . . X .	3+3+2 repeated - Afro-Cuban DNA
Habanera	X . . X . X . . X . . X . X . .	Dotted quarter + eighth feel - tango base
Cinquillo	X . X X . X X .	5-note Afro-Cuban pattern in 8 pulses
Cascara	X . X . X X . X . X . X X . X .	Rhythmic shell pattern from timbales
Off-Beat Accent	. X . X . X . X	All upbeats - floating feel
3 over 4	X . . X . . X . . X . . X . . X	Polyrhythmic grouping for tension

7. TRANSPOSITION GUIDE - Move Any Riff to All 12 Keys

Take any lick above and shift it by these intervals. Example: the Dorian riff D-F-A-C-A-F becomes:

Key	Root-b3-5-b7-5-b3	Key	Root-b3-5-b7-5-b3
D min	D F A C A F	Ab min	Ab Cb Eb Gb Eb Cb
Eb min	Eb Gb Bb Db Bb Gb	A min	A C E G E C
E min	E G B D B G	Bb min	Bb Db F Ab F Db
F min	F Ab C Eb C Ab	B min	B D F# A F# D
F# min	F# A C# E C# A	C min	C Eb G Bb G Eb
G min	G Bb D F D Bb	C# min	C# E G# B G# E

Practice method: Pick ONE riff per day. Play it in the original key 5 times, then move it through the cycle of 4ths: D - G - C - F - Bb - Eb - Ab - Db - F# - B - E - A. Use a metronome starting at 80 BPM.

Daily Routine - Quick Reference

10-Minute Warm-Up (Every Day)

1. Long tones on the tonic of today's key (2 min)
2. Major scale ascending/descending, full range (2 min)
3. Dorian scale in today's key with clave foot tap (3 min)
4. Minor pentatonic in today's key, varying rhythms (3 min)

Phase Routines

Phase	Time	Blocks
Phase 1 (Wk 1-4)	30 min	Scales 10m + Patterns 10m + Improvise 10m
Phase 2 (Wk 5-8)	35 min	New scales 10m + ii-V-i 10m + Bebop 5m + Improv 10m
Phase 3 (Wk 9-12)	40 min	Altered 10m + Tension compare 10m + Phrygian 5m + Transcribe 5m + Improv 10m
Phase 4 (Wk 13-16)	45 min	Tango cadences 10m + Adv. scales 10m + Tango vocab 10m + Transcribe 5m + Improv 10m

SCALE CHEAT SHEET: What to Play Over What

Chord Type	First Choice	Second Choice	Third Choice
Major 7	Major	Lydian	Lydian Augmented
Dominant 7	Mixolydian	Bebop Dominant	Lydian Dominant
Dominant 7b9	Spanish/Jewish	Diminished (H-W)	Altered
Dominant 7#9	Altered	Diminished (H-W)	Blues Scale
Dominant 7#5	Whole Tone	Altered	
Dominant 7sus4	Mixolydian (avoid 3rd)	Pentatonic on b7	Bebop
Dominant 7b6	Hindu		
Minor 7	Dorian	Minor Pentatonic	Blues Scale
Minor-Major 7	Melodic Minor	Harmonic Minor	
Minor b9 b6	Phrygian		
Half-diminished	Locrian #2	Locrian	
Diminished 7	Diminished (W-H)		

Listening Homework

Latin Jazz:

Paquito D'Rivera (alto sax model) | David Sanchez - Obsesion (tenor model)
Jerry Gonzalez & Fort Apache Band | Chucho Valdes | Eddie Palmieri
Mongo Santamaria | Michel Camilo

Tango:

Gato Barbieri - Chapter One: Latin America (tenor sax + tango)
Astor Piazzolla - Tango: Zero Hour | Libertango | Oblivion | Adios Nonino

16-Week Progress Tracker

Week	Keys Mastered	Scales Added	Tunes Learned	Solos Transcribed
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				
9				
10				
11				
12				
13				
14				
15				
16				

Common Latin Jazz Chord Progressions

Harmonic templates used across salsa, Afro-Cuban jazz, bossa nova, and tango

Each progression is shown in a common key with scale recommendations, then transposed to all 12 keys. Use these as vamp tracks for practicing your scales and riffs.

1. The Dorian Vamp (i7 - IV7)

Style: Salsa, Latin rock, cha-cha | Think: Oye Como Va, Evil Ways, Black Magic Woman

Bar	Chord	Scale	Notes
1-2	Am7	A Dorian: A B C D E F# G	Home base — emphasize F# (natural 6th)
3-4	D9	D Mixolydian: D E F# G A B C	Same notes as A Dorian — one scale fits all

Why it works: Am7 and D9 share the same notes (A Dorian = D Mixolydian). You can solo with one scale over the entire vamp. This is the simplest latin jazz progression and the best place to start.

Also try: A minor pentatonic, A blues scale, or switch between Dorian and pentatonic.

In all 12 keys:

Key	i7	IV7	Dorian Scale
A	Am7	D9	A B C D E F# G
Bb	Bbm7	Eb9	Bb C Db Eb F G Ab
B	Bm7	E9	B C# D E F# G# A
C	Cm7	F9	C D Eb F G A Bb
C#	C#m7	F#9	C# D# E F# G# A# B
D	Dm7	G9	D E F G A B C
Eb	Ebm7	Ab9	Eb F Gb Ab Bb C Db
E	Em7	A9	E F# G A B C# D
F	Fm7	Bb9	F G Ab Bb C D Eb
F#	F#m7	B9	F# G# A B C# D# E
G	Gm7	C9	G A Bb C D E F
Ab	Abm7	Db9	Ab Bb Cb Db Eb F Gb

2. The Minor ii-V-i

Style: The backbone of ALL latin jazz harmony | Think: Besame Mucho, Tin Tin Deo, Blue Bossa

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale	Tension Level
1-2	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C	Low
3-4	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F	Medium-High
5-8	Cm6	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B	Resolution

Dominant substitutions (try these on the V chord for different flavors):

V Chord Scale	Sound	When to Use
G Spanish/Jewish	Classic latin, Afro-Cuban	Default choice — always works
G Altered (Dim WT)	Maximum tension, modern jazz	When you want to push outside

V Chord Scale	Sound	When to Use
G Diminished (H-W)	Angular, symmetric	Over G7b9 for a jazzy edge
G Bebop Dominant	Smooth eighth-note lines	For flowing bebop-style lines
G Whole Tone	Floating, dreamy	Over G7#5 voicings

In all 12 minor keys:

Key	ii (half-dim)	V7(b9)	i
Cm	Dm7(b5)	G7(b9)	Cm
C#m	D#m7(b5)	G#7(b9)	C#m
Dm	Em7(b5)	A7(b9)	Dm
Ebm	Fm7(b5)	Bb7(b9)	Ebm
Em	F#m7(b5)	B7(b9)	Em
Fm	Gm7(b5)	C7(b9)	Fm
F#m	G#m7(b5)	C#7(b9)	F#m
Gm	Am7(b5)	D7(b9)	Gm
Abm	Bbm7(b5)	Eb7(b9)	Abm
Am	Bm7(b5)	E7(b9)	Am
Bbm	Cm7(b5)	F7(b9)	Bbm
Bm	C#m7(b5)	F#7(b9)	Bm

3. The Major ii-V-I

Style: Bossa nova, Latin jazz standards | Think: Desafinado, Girl from Ipanema, Corcovado

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-2	Dm7	ii	D Dorian: D E F G A B C
3-4	G7	V	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F (or Bebop Dom)
5-8	Cmaj7	I	C Major: C D E F G A B (or C Lydian)

In all 12 major keys:

Key	ii	V7	I
C	Dm7	G7	Cmaj7
Db	Ebm7	Ab7	Dbmaj7
D	Em7	A7	Dmaj7
Eb	Fm7	Bb7	Ebmaj7
E	F#m7	B7	Emaj7
F	Gm7	C7	Fmaj7
F#	G#m7	C#7	F#maj7
G	Am7	D7	Gmaj7
Ab	Bbm7	Eb7	Abmaj7
A	Bm7	E7	Amaj7
Bb	Cm7	F7	Bbmaj7
B	C#m7	F#7	Bmaj7

4. Cycle of Dominants

Style: Swing/latin bridge sections | Think: Caravan bridge, Autumn Leaves, rhythm changes bridge

Bar	Chord	Resolves to	Scale
1-2	F7	Bb7	F Mixolydian (or Bebop Dominant)
3-4	Bb7	Eb7	Bb Mixolydian
5-6	Eb7	Abmaj7	Eb Mixolydian
7-8	Abmaj7	(home)	Ab Major or Ab Lydian

Pattern: Each dominant 7th resolves down a perfect 5th to the next. Use Mixolydian or Bebop Dominant on each chord. This pattern appears in bridges of many standards.

Advanced: Try Spanish/Jewish on each dominant for a latin flavor, or Altered for maximum tension.

5. Phrygian Cadence (bII - V7(b9) - i)

Style: Tango, flamenco-jazz, dramatic latin | Think: Piazzolla, Caravan intro, Spanish-tinged jazz

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-2	Dbmaj7	bII	Db Lydian: Db Eb F G Ab Bb C
3-4	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
5-8	Cm	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B

The tango signature: The bII chord (a half step above the tonic) slides down to the V7(b9), then resolves to i. The augmented 2nd interval in the Spanish scale IS the sound of tango.

In all 12 minor keys:

i	bII	V7(b9)	i
Cm	Dbmaj7	G7(b9)	Cm
C#m	Dmaj7	G#7(b9)	C#m
Dm	Ebmaj7	A7(b9)	Dm
Ebm	Emaj7 (Fbmaj7)	Bb7(b9)	Ebm
Em	Fmaj7	B7(b9)	Em
Fm	Gbmaj7	C7(b9)	Fm
F#m	Gmaj7	C#7(b9)	F#m
Gm	Abmaj7	D7(b9)	Gm
Abm	Amaj7 (Bbbmaj7)	Eb7(b9)	Abm
Am	Bbmaj7	E7(b9)	Am
Bbm	Cbmaj7 (Bmaj7)	F7(b9)	Bbm
Bm	Cmaj7	F#7(b9)	Bm

6. bVI - V7(b9) - i (Dramatic Minor Cadence)

Style: Bolero, tango, dramatic ballads | Think: Besame Mucho, Obsesion

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-2	Abmaj7	bVI	Ab Major: Ab Bb C Db Eb F G
3-4	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
5-8	Cm	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B

This **cadence** is extremely common in bolero and tango. The bVI chord shares two notes with the i chord (Ab and C in Cm), creating a smooth voice-leading descent: Ab -> G -> G (bVI root drops to V root to resolve).

In all 12 keys:

i	bVI	V7(b9)
Cm	Abmaj7	G7(b9)
Dm	Bbmaj7	A7(b9)
Em	Cmaj7	B7(b9)
Fm	Dbmaj7	C7(b9)
Gm	Ebmaj7	D7(b9)
Am	Fmaj7	E7(b9)
Bbm	Gbmaj7	F7(b9)
Bm	Gmaj7	F#7(b9)

7. Salsa Montuno Vamp (I - IV - V - IV)

Style: Salsa, son montuno, descarga | The dance floor groove

Bar	Chord	Scale
1	C	C Major: C D E F G A B
2	F	F Major (or F Lydian)
3	G7	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F
4	F	F Major

Simplicity is power: This I-IV-V-IV loop drives hundreds of salsa tunes. Use C major pentatonic over the whole thing. Add blues notes for flavor. Focus on RHYTHM, not note complexity.

8. Guajira (Cuban 6/8-3/4 Hemiola)

Style: Traditional Cuban, guajira-son | Think: Guantanamera, Paquito D'Rivera's guajiras, Bebo Valdes

The signature sound: The guajira alternates between **6/8** and **3/4** feel — the same 6 eighth notes can be grouped as 2 groups of 3 (compound duple) or 3 groups of 2 (simple triple). This creates a rolling, rural, lyrical feel unlike anything else in latin music.

Classic Guajira Form (16 bars, alternating major/relative minor):

Bars	Chord	Feel	Scale
1-2	C	I (major, 6/8)	C Major Pentatonic: C D E G A
3-4	G7	V	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F
5-6	C	I	C Major: C D E F G A B
7-8	G7	V	G Mixolydian
9-10	Am	vi (shift to minor)	A Natural Minor: A B C D E F G
11-12	E7	V/vi	E Spanish/Jewish: E F G# A B C D
13-14	Am / Dm	vi / ii	A Aeolian / D Dorian
15-16	G7 / C	V / I (back home)	G Mixolydian / C Major

Scale strategy: Keep it simple and lyrical. Use major pentatonic in the major sections, natural minor (Aeolian) in the minor sections. The E7 to Am is the only dramatic moment — use E Spanish/Jewish here for the traditional Cuban flavor.

The 6/8 vs 3/4 Hemiola:

Feel	Grouping	Accent Pattern	Character
6/8	Two groups of 3: (1-2-3)(4-5-6)	> . . > . .	Flowing, rolling, pastoral
3/4	Three groups of 2: (1-2)(3-4)(5-6)	> . > . > .	March-like, lilting, Spanish
Combined	Alternate between them	Shifting accents	THE guajira sound

Practice tip: Play a C major scale for 6 beats. First pass in 6/8 (accent beats 1 and 4). Second pass in 3/4 (accent beats 1, 3, and 5). Once you can switch smoothly, you've got the guajira feel.

Simplified Guajira Vamp (for practice):

Bars	Chord	Scale
1-4	C	C Major Pentatonic
5-8	Am	A Natural Minor
9-12	Dm	D Dorian: D E F G A B C
13-16	G7 / C	G Mixolydian resolving to C Major

In all 12 keys (simplified I - V7 - vi - V/vi pattern):

Major Key	I	V7	vi	V7/vi
C	C	G7	Am	E7
Db	Db	Ab7	Bbm	F7
D	D	A7	Bm	F#7
Eb	Eb	Bb7	Cm	G7
E	E	B7	C#m	G#7
F	F	C7	Dm	A7
F#	F#	C#7	D#m	A#7
G	G	D7	Em	B7
Ab	Ab	Eb7	Fm	C7
A	A	E7	F#m	C#7
Bb	Bb	F7	Gm	D7
B	B	F#7	G#m	D#7

Why this matters: The guajira is the countryside soul of Cuban music — simpler and more melodic than the urban son montuno. Learning it gives you access to the lyrical, singable side of latin jazz. 'Guantanamera' is the most famous example — if you can play over its changes, you understand the guajira.

9. Minor Descending Cycle (i - iv - VII - III - VI - ii - V - i)

Style: Tango nuevo, sophisticated jazz | Think: Oblivion (Piazzolla), Autumn Leaves

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-2	Cm	i	C Dorian (or Melodic Minor)
3-4	Fm7	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
5-6	Bb7	VII	Bb Mixolydian: Bb C D Eb F G Ab
7-8	Ebmaj7	III	Eb Major: Eb F G Ab Bb C D
9-10	Abmaj7	VI	Ab Lydian: Ab Bb C D Eb F G
11-12	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
13-14	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
15-16	Cm	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B

The complete minor key journey: This cycle touches every diatonic chord in C minor. It descends by 4ths (C-F-Bb-Eb-Ab-D-G-C). This is the progression in Piazzolla's Oblivion and many jazz standards.

Scale strategy: Use Dorian/Melodic Minor on i, Dorian on iv, Mixolydian on VII and III area, Locrian #2 on ii, Spanish/Jewish on V, Harmonic Minor for final resolution.

10. Static Dominant Vamp

Style: Afro-Cuban, descarga, guaguanco | Think: Manteca A section, rumba jams

Bar	Chord	Scale Options
1-8+	Bb7 (static, no resolution)	Bb Mixolydian — safe, consonant Bb Lydian Dominant — bright #4 color Bb Blues — earthy, soulful Bb Bebop Dominant — smooth 8th-note lines

When the dominant doesn't resolve: Use Lydian Dominant instead of Mixolydian. The #4 prevents the chord from wanting to resolve, matching the static harmony. This is common in Afro-Cuban vamps where a dominant chord just grooves indefinitely.

11. Tritone Substitution Turnaround

Style: Modern bossa, sophisticated latin jazz | Think: Desafinado, jobim ballads

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1	Cmaj7	I	C Major
2	Db7(#11)	subV/I (tritone sub of G7)	Db Lydian Dominant: Db Eb F G Ab Bb Cb
3	Cmaj7	I	C Lydian: C D E F# G A B
4	B7(#11)	subV/ii (tritone sub of F7)	B Lydian Dominant: B C# D# E# F# G# A

Tritone substitutions replace a V7 chord with a dominant 7th a tritone away (e.g., Db7 replaces G7). The Lydian Dominant scale is THE scale for these chords. This is the sound of sophisticated bossa nova harmony (Jobim used this constantly).

Rule of thumb: See a dominant 7th with a #11 or b5? Use Lydian Dominant every time.

12. Latin Minor Blues (12-bar)

Style: Latin blues, Afro-Cuban blues | Think: Senor Blues, Blue Monk (latin arrangement)

Bar	Chord	Function	Scale
1-4	Cm7	i	C Dorian, C Minor Pentatonic, C Blues
5-6	Fm7	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
7-8	Cm7	i	C Dorian or C Blues
9	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C
10	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish or G Altered
11-12	Cm7	i	C Minor Pentatonic (turnaround)

The minor blues is a 12-bar form that bridges blues and jazz. You can play minor pentatonic or blues scale over the entire form, then get more specific with Dorian on the i, Spanish/Jewish on the V. Latin feel comes from the rhythm, not the harmony.

13. Piazzolla Tango Sequence (chromatic bass descent)

Style: *Tango nuevo* | Think: *Libertango, Adios Nonino, Buenos Aires Hora Cero*

Bar	Chord (over bass)	Bass Note	Scale
1	Am	A	A Harmonic Minor
2	Am/G#	G# (descending)	A Harmonic Minor (G# is the leading tone)
3	Am/G	G natural	A Dorian (G natural implies natural 7th descent)
4	Am/F#	F#	D Lydian Dominant or passing diminished
5	Dm/F	F	D Dorian or D Harmonic Minor
6	E7	E	E Spanish/Jewish: E F G# A B C D
7-8	Am	A	A Harmonic Minor (resolution)

The **chromatic descending bass line** (A - G# - G - F# - F - E) is the DNA of tango nuevo. While the bass descends chromatically, the upper harmony shifts between harmonic minor, dorian, and passing diminished sounds. This creates the dramatic, cinematic quality of Piazzolla.

Practice tip: Play A harmonic minor over the first 2 bars, then let your ear guide you through the chromatic descent. The E7 at the end is pure Spanish/Jewish territory.

Quick Reference: All 13 Progressions

#	Progression	Style	Key Scale(s)
1	i7 - IV7 (Dorian Vamp)	Salsa, cha-cha	Dorian, Minor Pentatonic
2	ii(b5) - V7(b9) - i (Minor ii-V-i)	All latin jazz	Locrian #2, Spanish/Jewish, Harm Minor
3	ii - V7 - I (Major ii-V-I)	Bossa nova	Dorian, Mixolydian, Major
4	V7/ii - V7/V - V7 - I (Cycle of Doms)	Swing/latin bridges	Mixolydian on each
5	bII - V7(b9) - i (Phrygian Cadence)	Tango, flamenco	Lydian, Spanish/Jewish, Harm Minor
6	bVI - V7(b9) - i	Bolero, tango	Major, Spanish/Jewish, Harm Minor
7	I - IV - V - IV (Montuno Vamp)	Salsa, son	Major Pentatonic
8	Guajira (6/8-3/4 hemiola, I-V-vi-E7)	Cuban countryside	Major Pentatonic, Natural Minor, Spanish
9	i-iv-VII-III-VI-ii-V-i (Minor Cycle)	Tango nuevo, jazz	Dorian, Mixolydian, Spanish
10	Static V7 (Dominant Vamp)	Afro-Cuban, descarga	Lydian Dominant, Mixolydian
11	I - subV - I (Tritone Sub)	Modern bossa	Lydian Dominant
12	12-bar Minor Blues	Latin blues	Blues, Dorian, Spanish
13	Chromatic Bass Descent	Tango nuevo	Harmonic Minor, Spanish

Tune Analysis

10 Latin Jazz & Tango Standards — Chord-to-Scale Mapping

For each chord, the recommended scale from your syllabus is shown. Practice the tune by playing through the form using these scale choices.

1. Oye Como Va

Tito Puente | Key: A Dorian | Form: 2-chord vamp (open) | Time: 4/4 Cha-cha | Difficulty: Beginner

Bars	Chord	Scale Choice	Notes
1-2	Am7	A Dorian: A B C D E F# G	The workhorse — emphasize the F# (natural 6th)
3-4	D9	D Mixolydian: D E F# G A B C	Or stay on A Dorian — same notes!

Why this tune: Perfect beginner tune. Two chords, infinite possibilities. Am7-D9 is a i-IV vamp in A Dorian. Since both chords share the same notes (A Dorian = D Mixolydian), you can play A Dorian or A minor pentatonic over the entire tune.

Practice tip: Start with A minor pentatonic only. Then add the F# (Dorian 6th). Then try A Blues scale for grit. Focus on RHYTHM over note choice — this tune is all about the groove.

2. Senor Blues

Horace Silver | Key: Eb minor | Form: 12-bar minor blues | Time: 6/8 Afro-Cuban | Difficulty: Beginner-Intermediate

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Ebm6/9	i	Eb Dorian: Eb F Gb Ab Bb C Db
3-4	Ebm6/9	i	Eb Minor Pentatonic: Eb Gb Ab Bb Db
5-6	Cb9 (B9)	bVI	Cb Mixolydian: Cb Db Eb Fb Gb Ab Bbb
7-8	Ebm6/9	i	Eb Blues: Eb Gb Ab A Bb Db
9	Bb7	V	Bb Spanish/Jewish: Bb Cb D Eb F Gb Ab
10	Ab7	IV	Ab Mixolydian: Ab Bb C Db Eb F Gb
11-12	Ebm6/9	i	Eb Dorian or Eb Minor Pentatonic

Why this tune: Bridges blues and latin jazz vocabulary. The 6/8 Afro-Cuban feel teaches you to think in a different rhythmic grid. The bVI chord (Cb9) is a classic minor blues move.

Practice tip: Eb minor pentatonic works over the entire form. Add Dorian for color. On the Bb7 (bar 9), try Spanish/Jewish for that latin V7 sound. The 6/8 feel means thinking in groups of 3.

3. Stolen Moments

Oliver Nelson | Key: C minor | Form: 12-bar minor blues + chromatic passage | Time: 4/4 | Difficulty: Intermediate

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-4	Cm7 / Cm6	i	C Dorian: C D Eb F G A Bb
5-6	Fm7 / Fm6	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
7-8	Cm7 / Cm6	i	C Dorian or C Minor Pentatonic
9	Dm7(b5)	ii (of V)	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C
10	G7(b13)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
11-12	Cm7 / Cm6	i	C Dorian

Chromatic Passage (the signature section):

Bar	Chord	Scale Choice
13	Dm11 / Ebm11	D Dorian / Eb Dorian (shift up a half step)
14	Em11 / Fm11	E Dorian / F Dorian (shift up a half step)
15	F#m11 / Fm11	F# Dorian / F Dorian (shift back down)
16	Em11 / Ebm11	E Dorian / Eb Dorian (continue descent)

Practice tip: The chromatic passage is a Dorian scale shifting up by half steps then back down. Practice Dorian in ALL keys — this tune tests whether you can move between them fluidly.

4. Besame Mucho

Consuelo Velazquez | Key: D minor | Form: ABA | Time: 4/4 Bolero | Difficulty: Intermediate

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
A: 1-2	Dm6	i	D Harmonic Minor: D E F G A Bb C#
3-4	Gm6	iv	G Dorian: G A Bb C D E F
5-6	Gm6 / D7(b9)	iv / V/iv	D7b9: D Spanish/Jewish: D Eb F# G A Bb C
7-8	Em7(b5) / A7(b9)	ii-V	Em7b5: E Locrian #2 / A7b9: A Spanish/Jewish
9-10	Dm6	i	D Melodic Minor: D E F G A B C#
11-12	A7(b9) / D7(b9)	V / V/iv	A Spanish: A Bb C# D E F G
13-14	Gm6	iv	G Harmonic Minor: G A Bb C D Eb F#
15-16	Bm7(b5) / E7(b9) / A7(b9)	ii-V-V	B Locrian #2 / E Spanish / A Spanish
Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
B: 1-2	Gm6	iv	G Dorian: G A Bb C D E F
3-4	Dm6	i	D Harmonic Minor
5-6	Em7(b5) / A7(b9)	ii-V	E Locrian #2 / A Spanish/Jewish
7-8	Dm6 / D7(b9)	i / V/iv	D Harm Minor / D Spanish

Why this tune: A masterclass in minor key harmony. Almost every dominant chord is a V7(b9) — perfect for drilling Spanish/Jewish scale. The Dm6 tonic invites both Harmonic Minor and Melodic Minor.

Practice tip: This tune is FULL of Spanish/Jewish opportunities. Practice A Spanish (A Bb C# D E F G) and D Spanish (D Eb F# G A Bb C) until they are automatic. The Em7(b5)-A7(b9)-Dm cadence appears repeatedly — this is the minor ii-V-i from Phase 2.

5. Tin Tin Deo

Chano Pozo / Gil Fuller / Dizzy Gillespie | Key: C minor | Form: AABA (32 bars) | Time: 4/4 Afro-Cuban | Difficulty: Intermediate

Intro Vamp (Latin feel):

Bars	Chord	Scale Choice
1-2	Cm7	C Dorian: C D Eb F G A Bb
3-4	Dm7(b5) / G7(b9)	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C / G Spanish: G Ab B C D Eb F

A Section:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Cm7	i	C Dorian

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
3-4	Fm7	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
5	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C
6	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
7-8	Cm7	i	C Minor Pentatonic: C Eb F G Bb

B Section (Bridge):

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Ebmaj7	III	Eb Major: Eb F G Ab Bb C D
3-4	Abmaj7	VI	Ab Lydian: Ab Bb C D Eb F G
5-6	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2
7-8	G7(b9)	V	G Spanish/Jewish or G Altered

Practice tip: The A section is a textbook minor jazz progression: i-iv-ii-V-i. The bridge lifts to the relative major (Eb). Practice switching between C Dorian (A section) and Eb Major (bridge) smoothly.

6. Obsesion

Pedro Flores | Key: A minor | Form: AB (32 bars) | Time: 4/4 Bolero | Difficulty: Intermediate

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
A: 1-2	Am	i	A Harmonic Minor: A B C D E F G#
3-4	F	VI	F Major: F G A Bb C D E
5-6	E7	V	E Spanish/Jewish: E F G# A B C D
7-8	Am	i	A Dorian: A B C D E F# G
9-10	Am	i	A Minor Pentatonic: A C D E G
11-12	G7	VII	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F
13-14	C	III	C Major: C D E F G A B
15-16	Dm / Am	iv / i	D Dorian / A Harmonic Minor
Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
B: 1-4	Am / F	i / VI	A Harm Minor / F Major
5-6	E7	V	E Spanish/Jewish
7-8	Am	i	A Harmonic Minor
9-10	A7	V/iv	A Mixolydian: A B C# D E F# G
11-12	G7	VII	G Mixolydian
13-14	C	III	C Major
15-16	E7 / Am	V / i	E Spanish / A Harmonic Minor

Practice tip: The bVI-V-i movement (F-E7-Am) is a classic tango/bolero cadence. Emphasize the G# in E Spanish/Jewish — it's the leading tone that pulls everything home to Am.

7. Caravan

Juan Tizol / Duke Ellington | Key: Fm / Ab major | Form: AABA (32 bars) | Time: 4/4 Latin/Swing | Difficulty: Intermediate

A Section (8 bars) — The exotic vamp:

Bars	Chord	Scale Choice	Notes
1-6	C7(b9)	C Spanish/Jewish: C Db E F G Ab Bb	THIS is the Caravan sound — Spanish scale for 6 bars
7-8	Fm6	F Harmonic Minor: F G Ab Bb C Db E	Resolution — the E natural pulls to F

B Section / Bridge (8 bars) — Swing feel, cycle of dominants:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	F7	V/ii	F Mixolydian: F G A Bb C D Eb
3-4	Bb7	V/V	Bb Mixolydian: Bb C D Eb F G Ab
5-6	Eb7	V	Eb Mixolydian: Eb F G Ab Bb C Db
7-8	Ab6	I	Ab Major: Ab Bb C Db Eb F G

Why this tune: THE Spanish/Jewish scale showcase. You sit on C7(b9) for 6 bars — pure Phrygian Dominant territory. The bridge shifts to Ab major with a cycle of dominants (Mixolydian practice). Two completely different sounds in one tune.

Practice tip: On the A section, learn to milk the C Spanish scale: C Db E F G Ab Bb. The Db-E augmented 2nd IS the Caravan sound. On the bridge, switch to Mixolydian mode thinking. Try Bebop Dominant for flowing lines over the cycle.

8. Libertango

Astor Piazzolla | Key: A minor | Form: AB (repeating) | Time: 4/4 Tango (136 BPM) | Difficulty: Intermediate

A Section (8 bars) — The iconic tango riff:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Am	i	A Harmonic Minor: A B C D E F G#
3-4	E7	V	E Spanish/Jewish: E F G# A B C D
5-6	Dm	iv	D Dorian: D E F G A B C
7-8	Am	i	A Minor Pentatonic: A C D E G

B Section (8 bars) — Opens up to relative major area:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Dm	iv	D Dorian or D Melodic Minor
3-4	G7	VII	G Mixolydian: G A B C D E F
5-6	C (Cmaj7)	III	C Major: C D E F G A B
7-8	E7	V	E Spanish/Jewish or E Altered

The A section bass line descends chromatically: A - G# - G - F# - F - E. This implies passing diminished chords. Over the chromatic descent, use A Harmonic Minor throughout.

Practice tip: Use 3-3-2 rhythmic grouping. The B section Dm-G7-C is a ii-V-I in C major — contrast the tango A with a jazzier B section. On the final E7, try E Altered for maximum tension before returning to Am.

9. Oblivion

Astor Piazzolla | Key: C minor | Form: ABA | Time: 4/4 Slow milonga | Difficulty: Intermediate-Advanced

A Section (16 bars) — Descending minor cycle:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Cm	i	C Melodic Minor: C D Eb F G A B
3-4	Fm7	iv	F Dorian: F G Ab Bb C D Eb
5-6	Bb7	VII	Bb Mixolydian: Bb C D Eb F G Ab
7-8	Ebmaj7	III	Eb Major: Eb F G Ab Bb C D
9-10	Abmaj7	VI	Ab Lydian: Ab Bb C D Eb F G
11-12	Dm7(b5)	ii	D Locrian #2: D E F G Ab Bb C
13-14	G7	V	G Spanish/Jewish: G Ab B C D Eb F
15-16	Cm	i	C Harmonic Minor: C D Eb F G Ab B

B Section (16 bars):

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Cm	i	C Dorian: C D Eb F G A Bb
3-4	Fm	iv	F Dorian or F Harmonic Minor
5-6	G7(sus4) / G7	V	G Mixolydian then G Spanish
7-8	Cm	i	C Melodic Minor
9-10	Abmaj7	VI	Ab Major or Ab Lydian
11-12	Bb7	VII	Bb Bebop Dominant
13-14	Ebmaj7	III	Eb Major
15-16	G7	V	G Altered: G Ab Bb B Db Eb F

Why this tune: A masterpiece of tango harmony. The A section is a full cycle through the key of C minor (i-iv-VII-III-VI-ii-V-i) — you touch almost every diatonic chord. This is the ultimate minor key navigation exercise.

Practice tip: Play slowly (this is a milonga, not a fast tango). Use Melodic Minor on the tonic for a smooth, modern sound. Switch to Harmonic Minor at the end of the A section for dramatic resolution. The Dm7(b5)-G7 is your Phase 2 ii-V in minor.

10. Desafinado

Antonio Carlos Jobim | Key: F major | Form: AABC (68 bars) | Time: 4/4 Bossa nova | Difficulty: Advanced

A Section (16 bars) — Chromatic ii-V motion:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
1-2	Fmaj7	I	F Major: F G A Bb C D E
3-4	G7(b5)	subV/vi	G Lydian Dominant: G A B C# D E F
5-6	Gm7 / C7	ii-V	G Dorian / C Bebop Dominant
7-8	Am7(b5) / D7(b9)	iii-VI(alt)	A Locrian #2 / D Spanish/Jewish
9-10	Gm7 / A7(b13)	ii / V/ii	G Dorian / A Altered
11-12	Bbmaj7 / Bbm6	IV / iv	Bb Major / Bb Dorian
13-14	Fmaj7	I	F Major or F Lydian
15-16	G7(b5) / Gb7	subV / bII7	G Lyd Dom / Gb Lydian Dominant

B Section — Modulation to A major then Ab major:

Bars	Chord	Function	Scale Choice
17-18	Fmaj7	I (home)	F Major
19-20	E7(#9)	V/iii (to A)	E Altered: E F G G# Bb C D
21-22	Amaj7	new I	A Major: A B C# D E F# G#
23-24	Bb7(#11)	subV (to A)	Bb Lydian Dominant: Bb C D E F G Ab
25-26	Amaj7	I (A major)	A Major
27-28	Bbm7 / Eb7	ii-V (to Ab)	Bb Dorian / Eb Bebop Dominant
29-30	Abmaj7	new I	Ab Major: Ab Bb C Db Eb F G
31-32	Db7	subV (to C)	Db Lydian Dominant
33-36	Cmaj7 / C#dim7 / Dm7 / G7	V area	C Major / Dim / G Dorian / G Bebop Dom

C Section returns to F major with the same A-section material, resolving through Am7(b5)-D7(b9)-Gm7 cadences.

Why this tune: The harmonic Everest of bossa nova. It modulates through F, A, and Ab major using tritone substitutions (Lydian Dominant territory) and altered dominants. This tune uses nearly EVERY scale in your syllabus.

Practice tip: Break it into 8-bar chunks. Master each modulation separately. The Lydian Dominant scale is crucial here — use it on every b5 or #11 dominant. The E7(#9) to Amaj7 is a classic altered dominant resolution. This is a Phase 4 tune — don't rush to it.

Tune Difficulty Progression

Suggested order for learning these tunes:

Order	Tune	Key Concept Practiced	Phase
1	Oye Como Va	Dorian vamp, pentatonic, rhythm focus	Phase 1
2	Senor Blues	Minor blues, Dorian + pentatonic, 6/8 feel	Phase 1
3	Stolen Moments	Minor blues + chromatic Dorian shifts	Phase 1-2
4	Libertango	Harmonic minor, tango rhythm, Spanish/Jewish	Phase 2
5	Caravan	Spanish/Jewish vamp, cycle of dominants	Phase 2
6	Besame Mucho	Minor ii-V-i, Spanish/Jewish everywhere	Phase 2
7	Tin Tin Deo	Full minor jazz form, Afro-Cuban	Phase 2-3
8	Obsesion	Bolero, bVI-V-i cadences	Phase 2-3
9	Oblivion	Full minor cycle, Melodic Minor, tango phrasing	Phase 3
10	Desafinado	Modulations, Lydian Dominant, Altered, all scales	Phase 4

Latin Jazz & Tango

Riffs, Licks & Melodic Patterns

For Alto & Tenor Saxophone — Transpose to all 12 keys

1. Latin Jazz Riffs — Minor Vamps

D Dorian (concert F for alto, C for tenor). Play over Dm7 montuno groove with clave.

1a. Pentatonic Call



1b. Falling Answer



1c. The Montuno Riff



1d. Root-5th Anchor (marcato)



1e. Dorian Signature (1-2-b3-5-4-2-1)

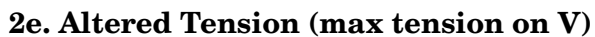
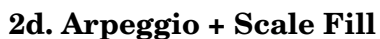


1f. Blue Note Dip (with b5 passing tone)





2a. Smooth Dorian-Spanish





2f. Pentatonic Shift (Dm pent → Db pent → Cm)



2g. Chromatic Approach (half steps into resolution)



2h. Spanish Signature (full Spanish run on V)



3. Dominant 7th — 8 Flavors of G7

Same chord, 8 different scale colors. Play each, hear the difference.

3a. Mixolydian (vanilla)



3b. Spanish / Jewish (salsa fire)



3c. Bebop Dominant (smooth 8th notes)

4



3d. Diminished H-W (angular, symmetric)



3e. Altered (maximum heat)



3f. Whole Tone (floating, dreamy)



3g. Blues (earthy, soulful)



3h. Lydian Dominant (bright, non-resolving)



4. Pentatonic Tricks

D minor pentatonic (D F G A C). Simple but powerful patterns.

4a. Ascending 4ths



4b. Falling 3rds



4c. 3-Note Cells (shifting up)



4d. Call & Response (leave space!)



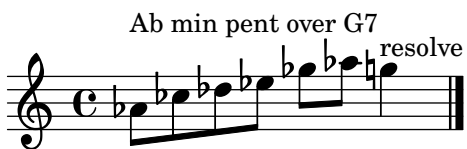
4e. Octave Displacement (dramatic jumps)



4f. Clave Pentatonic



4g. Ab min pent over G7 (b9, 3, b5, b13, b7 of G7)



5. Tango Melodic Patterns

A harmonic minor (concert C for alto, G for tenor). Use 3-3-2 feel.

5a. The Tango Sigh (upper neighbor, fall back)



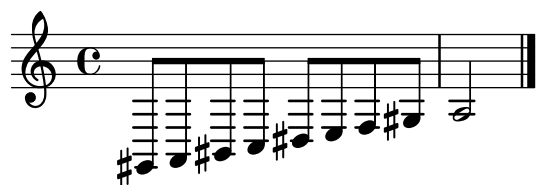
5b. Dramatic Leap + Stepwise Descent



5c. Augmented 2nd Cry (F–G#–A = tango DNA)



5d. Chromatic Approach (from half step below each note)



5e. Phrygian Cadence Lick (bII → V → i)



5f. Bandoneon Imitation (descending arpeggio, staccato)



5g. 3-3-2 Harmonic Minor Grouping



5h. Double Neighbor (surround from above & below)



5i. Piazzolla Sequence (rising 3rds through harm. minor)



5j. Tango Ending (turn on 5th, descend to tonic)



6. Rhythmic Patterns

Applied to D Dorian. Use these rhythms with ANY scale.

6a. Son Clave 3-2



6b. Anticipated Downbeat (push the 'one')



6c. Tresillo (3+3+2)

8



6d. Habanera (dotted quarter + eighth)



6e. Cinquillo



6f. Off-Beat Accents (all upbeats)



6g. 3-over-4 Polyrhythm (dotted quarters)



6h. Cascara-Inspired



7. Lick Transposition — Smooth Dorian-Spanish in 4 Key

The same lick (2a) moved to the 4 most common Latin jazz key centers.

C minor: Dm7 — G7b9 — Cm



F minor: Gm7 — C7b9 — Fm



G minor: Am7 — D7b9 — Gm



D minor: Em7 — A7b9 — Dm



Riffs & Licks in All 12 Keys

5 Essential Latin Jazz & Tango Patterns — Transposed for Practice

For Alto & Tenor Saxophone

Lick 1: Pentatonic Call

Ascending minor pentatonic burst — use over any minor 7th vamp

C minor



D♭ minor



D minor



E♭ minor



E minor



F minor



F♯ minor



G minor



2

Ab minor



A minor



Bb minor



B minor



Lick 2: Smooth Dorian-Spanish ii-V-i

The essential Latin jazz ii-V-i lick. Dorian on ii, Spanish /Jewish on V, resolve to i.

C minor: Dm7 — G7b9 — Cm



Db minor: Ebm7 — Ab7b9 — Dbm



D minor: Em7 — A7b9 — Dm



Eb minor: Fm7 — Bb7b9 — Ebm



E minor: F#m7 — B7b9 — Em



F minor: Gm7 — C7b9 — Fm



F# minor: G#m7 — C#7b9 — F#m



G minor: Am7 — D7b9 — Gm



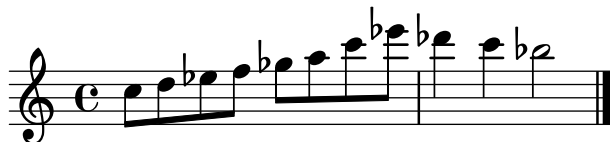
Ab minor: Bbm7 — Eb7b9 — Abm



A minor: Bm7 — E7b9 — Am



Bb minor: Cm7 — F7b9 — Bbm



B minor: C#m7 — F#7b9 — Bm



Lick 3: Spanish Signature Run

Full ascending Spanish/Jewish scale on V7b9, resolving to i. THE Latin dominant sound.

V = G7b9 → Cm



4

V = Ab7b9 → Dbm



V = A7b9 → Dm



V = Bb7b9 → Ebm



V = B7b9 → Em



V = C7b9 → Fm



V = C#7b9 → F#m



V = D7b9 → Gm



V = Eb7b9 → Abm



V = E7b9 → Am



V = F7b9 → Bbm



V = F#7b9 → Bm



Lick 4: Tango Augmented 2nd Cry

Scale degrees 5–b6–7–1–7–b6–5 of harmonic minor. The aug-2nd interval (b6→7) is the tango DNA.

A minor — E F G# A G# F E



Bb minor — F Gb A Bb A Gb F



B minor — F# G A# B A# G F#



C minor — G Ab B C B Ab G



C# minor — G# A B# C# B# A G#



D minor — A Bb C# D C# Bb A



Eb minor — Bb Cb D Eb D Cb Bb

6



E minor — B C D# E D# C B



F minor — C Db E F E Db C



F# minor — C# D E# F# E# D C#



G minor — D Eb F# G F# Eb D



Ab minor — Eb Fb G Ab G Fb Eb



Lick 5: Chromatic Approach into Resolution

Descend from ii through V with chromatic half steps landing on the tonic. Works over any ii-V-i.

→ C (Dm7 — G7 — C)



→ Db



→ D



→ Eb



→ E



→ F



→ F#



→ G



→ Ab



→ A



→ Bb



→ B

